outstanding services. Sir Pherozeshah asked him to refuse saying that the least he should have been given was a CIE[3], and even offered to draft the letter of refusal. Purshotamdas's answer, which was a model of logic and propriety, silenced even Sir Pherozeshah. 'I don't care for the honour,' he told Sir Pherozeshah, 'but if I refused it and then accepted a bigger honour later, it would only mean one thing—that I worked on the Famine Fund hoping for some award. And I didn't.'[4]

The First World War brought prosperity to most cotton traders and Purshotamdas was no exception. The war boom enabled him to consolidate and expand his business. In 1916, he was nominated to the Bombay Legislative Council where he spoke with authority on problems such as food supply, irrigation and livestock, all knowledge gained from his experience while working for the Relief Fund. In those days all power was concentrated in the government and members of the Legislature could at best prod the authorities by arousing public opinion. Purshotamdas while criticizing official acts also suggested positive remedies. He spoke on subjects with which he was familiar and that too after careful examination of all the relevant facts. As a result, his speeches were always listened to with respect by the government benches.

In 1920, when under the Government of India Act of 1919, the Legislative Council was replaced by the Bombay Legislative Assembly, Purshotamdas entered the new Legislature as a representative of Bombay's cotton trade. Here, as in the old Council, he spoke fearlessly, and with his accustomed vigour headed the opposition to taxes on entertainment at cinemas and theatres. His oratory even drew applause from the President of the Assembly, Sir Narayan Chandavarkar, a man not predisposed to excessive eulogy.

Purshotamdas was appointed to various committees by the government who had noted his sense of fairness, sincere effort, and painstaking thoroughness in all matters. In 1920, he was nominated to the Indian Railway Committee presided over by Sir William Acworth and known popularly as the Acworth Committee. The nine-member Acworth Committee was set up to investigate into the question of railway management and finance. The more immediate reason was that the contract of the company managing the East Indian Railway had expired and given the demand for nationalization of the country's railways in Indian political